

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1166

By Capley

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Billy Gene and Doris Jean Skinner Beckham of Clifton.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to honor the memory of those esteemed individuals whose lives of service and dedication left an indelible mark upon their communities and the State of Tennessee; and

WHEREAS, two such individuals are Billy Gene and Doris Jean Skinner Beckham of Clifton, who distinguished themselves as public-spirited citizens of the greatest dedication, ability, and integrity throughout their lives; and

WHEREAS, Bill Beckham was born in 1925 on Indian Creek in Wayne County in the Three Churches community; he was a lifelong cattle farmer, and from a young age, he was inspired by and understood the values of hard work and land stewardship; and

WHEREAS, he proudly served his nation as a member of the United States Navy during World War II, earning the Victory Medal and the Asiatic-Pacific Medal for his meritorious service; he received an honorable discharge in 1946 and was a longtime member of the American Legion, honoring and supporting fellow veterans; and

WHEREAS, Bill Beckham devoted much of his life to civic duty, serving as vice mayor of Clifton from 1972 to 1974; he was twice elected mayor and served from 1974 to 1976 and 1990 to 1998, earning the respect and admiration of his fellow citizens for his steady and practical leadership and deep-rooted love for his hometown; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Beckham operated the Sinclair gas station in Clifton, where conversations flowed freely, much like the fuel he supplied; he took his much-deserved retirement from Production Credit Services in 1983; and

WHEREAS, Doris Jean Skinner was born in 1929 in Henderson; her father worked in the timber industry, and as a young girl, she lived in several different parts of the state before her family ultimately settled in Clifton in 1940, planting roots that left a lasting imprint on the town; and

WHEREAS, in 1940, the Skinner family opened a five-and-dime store, adjacent to the historic Russ Hotel; in 1947, the store was moved across the street and became a community staple and gathering place; and

WHEREAS, Doris Skinner graduated from Frank Hughes School and attended Draughons' Business College before returning home to help care for her mother and operate the family's beloved storefront; and

WHEREAS, for decades, the store was the heartbeat of downtown Clifton; Doris Skinner employed countless individuals throughout the years and taught them responsibility, kindness, and the importance of knowing individuals by name; and

WHEREAS, after the store closed its doors in 1988, Doris Skinner found employment at Willoughby Drug Store and Dollar General and continued to greet customers with her warm smile and servant's heart; and

WHEREAS, Bill Beckham and Doris Skinner were united in marriage in 1950 and lived lives marked by integrity, humility, generosity, and an abiding love for their hometown; they wholly believed in honoring faith, family, and their country, providing young people with opportunities, and showing up for others when it mattered the most; and

WHEREAS, Bill and Doris Beckham were devout members of the Presbyterian Church in Clifton; Mr. Beckham served as chairman of the board for the daycare, investing in the youngest members of the community and ensuring a nurturing future for them; and

WHEREAS, Bill and Doris Beckham were consistent in their service and paved the way for others through their legacy of civic duty, sacrifice, leadership, and love that will forever remain woven into the Clifton community's story; and

WHEREAS, Bill and Doris Beckham represented a generation that built communities not for recognition but simply because it was the right thing to do; their spirit of adventure, unwavering work ethic, pride in Clifton, and devotion to their neighbors have left a legacy that continues to resonate through the community they so ably served; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Billy Gene and Doris Jean Skinner Beckham of Clifton, reflecting with gratitude upon their lives of service and extending our deepest respect to their family and all those who continue to cherish their memory.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.